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Floods: How to protect your health

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How do I protect my health in a flood?

Since floods can potentially increase the transmission of water- and vector-borne diseases, such as typhoid fever, cholera, malaria, and yellow fever, among others, it is important to know your risk and protect your water sources. The most common risks associated with flooding is the contamination of drinking-water facilities, and standing water, which can be a breeding site for mosquitoes, bring chemical hazards, and cause injuries.

Protect your health during a flood by:

1. **Knowing your community's evacuation route and warning signals, and identifying areas prone to flooding or landslides.**
2. **Chlorinating or boiling all water for drinking and food preparation**
Ensuring uninterrupted provision of safe drinking water is the most important preventive measure to be implemented following flooding, in order to reduce the risk of outbreaks of water-borne diseases.
3. **Promoting good hygienic practices and safe food preparation techniques**
Do not use flood water to wash dishes, brush teeth or wash and prepare food. Always wash your hands with soap and water if you have been in contact with floodwater.
4. **Avoiding walking or driving through flooded areas and standing water.**
Even the smallest amount of water can bring about significant dangers. You do not know if electrical lines have fallen in the water or hazardous chemicals exist. Cars and people can easily be swept away during a flood.

5. Throwing away any food that has come in contact with floodwater.

If your food has touched any floodwater, it is not safe to eat and increases your risk of water-borne diseases.

6. Safely cleaning your home if it has come in contact with floodwater.

Throw out any items that cannot be washed and cleaned with bleach, such as pillows and mattresses. Clean all walls, floors and other surfaces with soap and water, as well as bleach.

7. Protect against mosquitos

If your home is in an area with stagnant or standing water, use mosquito repellent, following the instructions on the label, and apply it to clothes or skin. Also wear trousers and long-sleeved shirts, and cover beds with mosquito nets when sleeping.

Additional resources

- [Drinking water](#)
- [Vector-borne diseases](#)
- [Five Keys to Safer Food](#)